



Focus group facilitation · volunteer-run

Focus Group

A facilitation guide for running a focus group about reflexive AI in your organization.

// WHY THIS FOCUS GROUP

Uncover how your organization can use AI effectively, responsibly and in a human-centered way.

It gathers evidence for a shared framework — and gives people in your organization space to discuss what human-centered AI means for them.

Face-to-face, ≈90 minutes

Best in person; adapts easily to online breakout rooms.

15–25 participants, 5 topics

A World Café across five stations, each moderated by a host.

PART OF

The Reflexive AI Research Initiative — a study by the Lucid Institute for Organizational Science.

FACILITATOR _____ DATE _____

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

About this guide

This guide helps you run a focus group about reflexive AI in your organization. It provides invaluable data for our research initiative to build a framework for effective, responsible, human-centered AI — and a chance for your organization to discuss what this means for them.

It typically takes 90 minutes. We recommend a face-to-face setting, but the format adapts easily to online breakout rooms.

How to run

This focus group is part of a research initiative. It is important to:

- Ensure all participants know this, and that the (anonymous) results will be shared with the research team.
- Avoid biasing participants in a certain direction (e.g. “AI is great” or “AI is terrible”).
- If you must modify the format, ensure the informed consent form is filled in first and discussions are moderated by hosts. Please notify us of any changes.

HOW TO PREPARE

How to prepare

How to invite people

- Clarify the aim: to uncover how organizations can use AI effectively, responsibly and in a human-centered way. Keep your invitation free from bias (e.g. “let’s talk about why AI is wonderful” or “let’s list why AI is terrible”).
- For the best outcomes, maximize the number of people with decision-making authority around AI.
- Emphasize that the discussion is part of a scientific study whose insights will be shared with the research initiative.

Materials

- Print the topic sheets (5 total).
- Print the station host protocol (5 total).
- Print the informed consent forms (1 per participant).
- Bring stickies, markers and pens, and empty flip charts (10–20).
- A timer is useful to track time.
- A buzzer or tingsha bell is useful to indicate new rounds.
- Optionally, bring snacks and drinks for a relaxed atmosphere.

Practical preparation

- In a physical space, create five stations — five tables with 4–6 chairs, or five flipcharts/whiteboards. Ensure each has one topic sheet and one station host protocol. Add markers, stickies, snacks and drinks.
- If you run this online, use our Miro template.
- Ideally, pick five station hosts upfront and ensure they’ve read the station host protocol.



🕒 15 min

Impromptu Networking

We begin the session with an opener to build connections and get our thinking started.

Steps

- Ask “What have you observed, noticed or wondered about how AI is used within our organization?” Give participants 1 minute to reflect on this in silence.
- **5 min** Now, ask participants to form pairs and take 4 minutes to respond to the question. If you have an uneven number, one group will have three participants.
- **5 min** Now, ask participants to form new pairs, and again take 4 minutes to respond to the question and build on the previous conversation.
- **5 min** Now, ask participants to form new pairs once more, and again take 4 minutes to respond and build on the previous conversations.
- Don’t debrief the discussions. The next exercise is ideal for this.
- Introduce the topic for this focus group: to explore what human-centered AI use looks like in your organization, and what can be done to ensure it.



🕒 10 min

Informed Consent

In this step, participants have the opportunity to give their consent to taking part in a scientific study. Good research requires informed consent.

Steps

- Ask all participants to complete the informed consent form. If a person does not wish to consent, this is perfectly fine — however, they cannot continue participating in the session.
- Collect the forms.



⌚ 60 min

World Café

We use World Café as the primary format for the focus groups. We assume 15–25 participants. In this format, each participant discusses 3 out of 5 topics in small groups at different stations, each moderated by a host.

How to run

- Introduce the aim: to engage in multiple rounds of small-group discussions around 5 topics, each at a different station, and to capture the output on sheets.
- Explain the general format. Participants distribute evenly across the stations. At each, a host facilitates a small-group discussion and captures insights on a sheet. After 15 minutes, a new round starts and participants move to another station and a new topic.
- Invite participants to distribute evenly across the stations. If you did not pick hosts upfront, ask each small group to choose one of their own to act as host. Ensure each group familiarizes themselves with the station host protocol.
- **15 min** Begin round 1 ("Discussion"). Invite the participants at each table to discuss their topic openly and collaboratively for 15 minutes. The hosts moderate the discussion, write down group insights and ensure the host protocol is followed. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 2 ("Discussion"). Ask participants to redistribute evenly across the stations, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite them to discuss their new topic with the station host, who continues moderating and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 3 ("Discussion"). Ask participants to redistribute again, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite them to discuss their new topic with the station host, who continues moderating and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **20 min** Bring everyone together again and ensure everyone has a marker or pen in hand. Ask the hosts to bring the sheets from their station. Ask a host to step forward and summarize the core insights from their table. When done, all participants (except the host) step forward to distribute three dots across the insights they deem most important on that sheet. Repeat until all hosts have summarized and all sheets have been dot-voted on.

Station topics

- What does "human-centered AI" look like in your organization? What happens, what does not happen? What do you hear people say or ask?
- Under what conditions has AI been used in your organization in a manner that supported people and teams?
- Where in your organization was the use of AI not human-centered, not responsible, or not effective — or where could you see it easily sliding down that path?
- What procedures, rules or processes must be implemented to ensure responsible, human-centered AI use in your organization?
- What could be measured, tracked or audited to ensure that the way your organization uses AI is responsible and human-centered?

HOW TO SEND RESULTS TO US

Please share the following with us to contribute to the research:

- Clear pictures or scans of the station sheets, including dot votes.
- Any notes from the hosts or facilitators on how the session went.
- Any changes you made to the facilitation format.
- Scans or pictures of the filled-in informed consent forms for all participants — unfortunately, we cannot process data without informed consent.

Send the materials to research@lucidinstitute.org.